

Word family: see / sees / saw / seen / seeing / seer

Base word: see

Past tense: saw

Past participle: seen

-ing form: seeing

Useful lexical extension: seer

Important constructions: see + object, see that..., see if/whether..., see someone, see a doctor, see someone as..., see why/how..., see someone doing..., see page..., we'll see, you see

Part of speech: mainly verb (動詞)

Your sentence:

"I **saw** it about a year ago when I was watching television late at night after work."

A full family sweep shows that **see is one of English's richest perception verbs**.

Its central idea is:

become aware of something through sight or mental understanding

From that, modern English develops meanings involving:

- physical vision;
 - noticing;
 - understanding;
 - realizing;
 - imagining;
 - experiencing;
 - meeting/visiting people;
 - consulting professionals;
 - dating;
 - checking/investigating;
 - ensuring something happens;
 - considering someone/something in a particular way;
 - referring readers elsewhere;
 - and several conversational expressions.
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Meaning in your passage

Here:

“I **saw** it about a year ago...”

means:

I visually encountered/watched the advertisement on television.

繁體中文：我當時在電視上看到了那則廣告

Natural translation:

“I saw it about a year ago...”

「我大約在一年前看到那則廣告……」

Here:

see = 透過眼睛注意到／看到某個影像或事物

Because this was a TV commercial, Chinese naturally uses:

看到／看見那則廣告

rather than a highly literal “視覺感知”.

1. **see + person/thing** (視覺) — 看見; 看到

This is your original core meaning.

Meaning: To become aware of someone or something through your eyes.

Practice 1 — Original

“I **saw** the advertisement about a year ago.”

「我大約一年前看到那則廣告。」

Practice 2

“I can **see** the station from here.”

「我從這裡可以看到車站。」

Practice 3

“Did you **see** that sign?”

「你有看到那個牌子嗎？」

see = 透過視覺察覺某人／某物存在

2. **see + event/show/film** (觀看內容) — 看；觀看

Depending on context, **see** can mean watch or attend something.

Practice 4

“We **saw** a film last night.”

「我們昨晚看了一部電影。」

Practice 5

“Have you **seen** the new documentary?”

「你看過那部新紀錄片嗎？」

see a film/show = 看過／觀看某部電影、表演或節目

This is related to physical sight, but the emphasis is on **experiencing the whole piece of content**.

3. **see = notice / become aware of visually** (注意到) — 發現；注意到

This is slightly more than simply having something in your visual field.

Practice 6

“I **saw** a mistake in the report.”

「我注意到／發現報告裡有一個錯誤。」

Practice 7

“She suddenly **saw** smoke coming from the kitchen.”

「她突然注意到廚房冒出煙來。」

see = 透過視覺察覺到某項值得注意的資訊或變化

4. **see = understand** (意思／觀點／問題) — 明白；理解

A major figurative meaning.

Practice 8

“I **see** what you mean.”

「我明白你的意思。」

Practice 9

“Do you **see** the problem?”

「你明白問題所在嗎？」

see = 在思想上理解某個意思、關係、問題或觀點

This is one of the most important metaphorical extensions:

physical seeing → mental understanding

5. I see = I understand / now I realize — 我明白了；原來如此

A very common conversational use.

Practice 10

“The battery only lasts ten hours.”

“Oh, I **see**.”

「電池只能用十小時。」

「哦，我明白了／原來如此。」

Practice 11

“You need to press this button first.”

“I **see**.”

「你需要先按這個按鈕。」

「明白了。」

I see = 表示自己已理解剛才得到的資訊或解釋

6. see why/how/what + clause (理解原因／方式) — 明白為甚麼／怎樣／甚麼

Practice 12

“I can **see why** the advertisement was effective.”

「我能明白為甚麼這則廣告有效。」

Practice 13

“Now I **see how** the system works.”

「現在我明白這個系統怎樣運作了。」

see why/how/what = 理解某個原因、機制、關係或情況

7. see + person (見面) — 見; 會見; 跟.....碰面

Meaning: To meet someone, either socially or by arrangement.

Practice 14

"I'm **seeing** Anna tomorrow."

「我明天會見 Anna／跟 Anna 見面。」

Practice 15

"I haven't **seen** him for months."

「我已經幾個月沒有見過他。」

see someone = 與某人見面、碰面或相處

This does not merely mean visually noticing the person.

8. see + doctor/lawyer/specialist (專業人士) — 看醫生; 諮詢; 求診

A very important contextual meaning.

Practice 16

"You should **see a doctor**."

「你應該去看醫生／求診。」

Practice 17

"She decided to **see a lawyer**."

「她決定找律師諮詢。」

see a professional = 親自會見專業人士，以取得診斷、建議或專業協助

Chinese changes naturally:

- see a doctor → 看醫生
 - see a lawyer → 諮詢律師
 - see a therapist → 接受治療／見治療師
-

9. **see someone** (戀愛關係) — 跟某人約會；正在交往

A genuinely distinct modern conversational use.

Practice 18

“Are you **seeing** anyone?”

「你現在有沒有跟誰約會／交往？」

Practice 19

“She has been **seeing** someone for a few months.”

「她已經跟某人交往了幾個月。」

see someone = 與某人處於約會／初期戀愛關係

Context is crucial:

“I’m seeing my doctor.”

= 我要去看醫生

“I’m seeing John.”

could mean:

- 我要見 John；
- 我正在跟 John 約會。

10. see = experience/witness an event or period (經歷／見證) — 經歷；見證

Practice 20

“The city has **seen** enormous change.”

「這座城市經歷了／見證了巨大的變化。」

Practice 21

“The industry has **seen** rapid growth.”

「這個行業經歷了快速增長。」

see — experience = 某個人、地方、時期或制度經歷／出現某種事件或變化

This is very common in formal writing.

11. see + someone/something + doing (目睹動作) — 看見……正在做……

Practice 22

“I **saw him leaving** the office.”

「我看見他正在離開辦公室。」

Practice 23

“We **saw people waiting** outside.”

「我們看見有人正在外面等候。」

see someone doing = 視覺上看到某人正在進行某項動作

12. see + someone/something + base verb (看到完整動作) — 看見.....做了.....

A useful grammar distinction.

Practice 24

“I **saw him leave** the office.”

「我看見他離開了辦公室。」

Practice 25

“We **saw the train arrive**.”

「我們看見火車抵達。」

see someone do = 看見一個動作從發生到完成, 被視為完整事件

Compare:

saw him leaving

= 看見他正在離開(過程)

saw him leave

= 看見他離開了(完整事件)

Excellent MCQ material.

13. see if/whether + clause (查清／看看) — 看看; 查明; 確認

Meaning: To check or find out whether something is true or possible.

Practice 26

“I’ll **see if** the headphones are still available.”

「我會看看／查一下那副耳機是否仍有貨。」

Practice 27

“Let’s **see whether** the new method works.”

「我們看看新方法是否有效。」

see if/whether = 查明、確認或試著了解某件事情是否成立

This is not literal visual seeing.

14. **see that + clause** (確保) — 確保; 務必使

.....

A useful formal construction.

Practice 28

“Please **see that** the door is locked.”

「請確保門已鎖好。」

Practice 29

“The manager **saw that** every customer received a reply.”

「經理確保每位顧客都收到回覆。」

see that something happens = 負責確保某件事情確實發生／完成

This can sound somewhat formal.

15. see someone/something as + noun/adjective (看待／視為) — 把.....視為; 認為.....是

Practice 30

“Customers **see** the brand **as** reliable.”

「顧客把這個品牌視為可靠的品牌。」

Practice 31

“She **sees** the problem **as** an opportunity.”

「她把問題視為一個機會。」

see A as B = 以某種觀點理解、評價或看待 A, 認為 A 屬於 B

This is mental perception/judgment.

16. see + possibility/future (想像／預見) — 想像; 認為可能; 預見

Practice 32

“I can’t **see** that happening.”

「我很難想像／不認為那件事會發生。」

Practice 33

“Can you **see yourself** working there?”

「你能想像自己在那裡工作嗎？」

see = 在腦中想像某種未來情況, 或判斷其是否可能發生

17. see + point/reason/value (認同／理解其價值) — 看出；理解；認同

Practice 34

“I can **see the value** of noise-cancelling headphones.”

「我能看出／理解降噪耳機的價值。」

Practice 35

“I don’t **see the point** of buying another pair.”

「我看不出／不明白再買一副有甚麼意義。」

see the point/value/reason = 理解某件事的道理、價值或理由

18. see + page/section/reference (文件指引) — 參見；查看

A common academic/formal use.

Practice 36

“For more information, **see page 20.**”

「更多資料請參見第 20 頁。」

Practice 37

“See the final section for details.”

「詳情請參閱最後一節。」

see + reference = 指示讀者前往另一頁、章節或資料來源查看相關內容

This is very common in:

- textbooks

- manuals
 - reports
 - academic writing
-

19. we'll see = wait and find out — 到時看看；再說；拭目以待

A very common conversational expression.

Practice 38

“Do you think the product will succeed?”
“**We'll see.**”

「你覺得產品會成功嗎？」
「到時看看吧／拭目以待。」

Practice 39

“Can I buy another pair?”
“**We'll see.**”

「我可以再買一副嗎？」
「到時再說。」

we'll see = 現在不作確定判斷，等待未來情況提供答案

Depending on tone, it can sound:

- neutral;
 - cautious;
 - noncommittal;
 - parental “maybe”.
-

20. you see = 用來解釋／補充原因 — 你看；其實；因為嘛

A common discourse marker.

Practice 40

"I bought them because, **you see**, I was commuting every day."

「我買了它們，你看／其實是因為我當時每天都要通勤。」

Practice 41

"It wasn't easy, **you see**, because we had very little time."

「事情並不容易，你要知道／因為嘛，我們時間很少。」

you see = 用來引出解釋、理由或希望對方理解的背景資訊

It does not literally mean “你看到”.

21. **see + someone + safely/home/out** (陪同／送) — 看著／陪同確保安全

There are constructions such as:

"I'll see you home."

= 我送你回家。

Practice 42

"He **saw her safely home**."

「他把她安全送回家。」

Practice 43

"The host **saw the guests to the door**."

「主人把客人送到門口。」

see someone + destination = 陪同某人到某個地方，確保其順利到達

This is somewhat more formal/old-fashioned than simply **walk/drive someone home**, but still useful.

22. seeing = act/ability of seeing (視覺／觀看) — 看見；視覺活動

Most uses of **seeing** are simply the -ing form, but it can function noun-like.

Practice 44

“**Seeing** clearly is difficult in the fog.”

「在霧中要看清楚很困難。」

Practice 45

“Seeing is believing.”

「眼見為實。」

seeing = 看見／目睹這種行為或經驗

23. seeing that / seeing as (既然；鑑於) — 既然；考慮到

A useful conjunction-like extension, especially conversational British English.

Practice 46

“**Seeing that** it was late, we went home.”

「既然／鑑於已經很晚，我們便回家了。」

Practice 47

“**Seeing as** you're here, you may as well stay.”

「既然你都來了，不如留下吧。」

seeing that/as = 根據某個已知事實，引出合理的結果；既然／鑑於

Seeing as is more conversational.

24. seer = person believed to foresee the future — 預言者；先知

A genuine lexical family extension, though not core everyday vocabulary.

Practice 48

“The story describes a **seer** who predicts the future.”

「故事描述了一位能預知未來的預言者。」

Practice 49

“People travelled far to consult the **seer**.”

「人們從遠方來請教那位預言者／先知。」

seer = 被認為能看見／預知一般人無法知道的未來或隱秘事情的人

This is literary, historical, religious, or fantasy vocabulary.

Important distinction: see vs look

This is one of the most important perception-verb contrasts.

see

= visual information reaches your eyes, often without deliberate effort.

“I can see the train.”

「我看得見火車。」

look

= deliberately direct your eyes toward something.

“Look at the train.”

「看看那列火車。」

Think:

look = action of directing the eyes

see = result of visual perception

Important distinction: see vs watch

You curated **watch** earlier.

see

can mean perceive or experience visually.

watch

means deliberately look at something for a period of time, especially when it moves/changes.

“I saw an advertisement.”

「我看到一則廣告。」

“I was watching television.”

「我正在看電視。」

This distinction appears **inside your own sentence**.

“I **saw** it when I was **watching** television.”

Perfect example:

- **saw** = noticed/encountered the ad
 - **watching** = continuously viewing TV
-

Important distinction: see vs notice

see

broad visual perception.

notice

means become consciously aware of something that stands out.

“I saw several people.”

「我看到幾個人。」

“I noticed that one person looked worried.”

「我注意到其中一個人看起來很擔心。」

You can **see** something without particularly **noticing** it.

Important distinction: see vs understand

understand

neutral, explicit mental comprehension.

see

often more conversational/metaphorical.

“I understand your point.”

“I see your point.”

Both:

「我明白你的觀點。」

But **I see** often conveys:

“Ah, now it makes sense.”

Important distinction: see vs meet

meet

often emphasizes coming together, especially for the first time or by arrangement.

see

often emphasizes spending time/meeting someone known.

“Nice to meet you.”

第一次見面常用。

“It was nice to see you again.”

再次見面常用。

Not a rigid rule, but very useful.

Important distinction: see vs visit

visit

focuses on going to a place/person and spending time there.

see

can simply mean meet.

“I’m going to visit my grandmother.”

「我要去探望祖母。」

“I’m seeing my grandmother tomorrow.”

「我明天會見祖母。」

The second says less about duration/location.

Important distinction: see someone vs see a doctor

The grammar looks identical, but context changes the meaning:

“I’m seeing Emma.”

could mean:

- meeting Emma;
- dating Emma.

“I’m seeing a doctor.”

normally:

- consulting/visiting a doctor.

This is a good example of why contextual Chinese translation matters.

Important distinction: see someone do vs see someone doing

see someone do

= perceive the complete event.

“I saw him cross the road.”

「我看見他過了馬路。」

see someone doing

= perceive the action while it is in progress.

“I saw him crossing the road.”

「我看見他正在過馬路。」

This is a very valuable grammar distinction.

Important distinction: see if vs know if

see if

= actively check/find out.

“I’ll see if it works.”

「我看看它是否有效。」

know if

= already have the information.

“I don’t know if it works.”

「我不知道它是否有效。」

Important distinction: see as vs think of as

They overlap:

“I see the product as practical.”

“I think of the product as practical.”

Both involve mental categorization.

See as often emphasizes **how one interprets/perceives something**.

Important distinction: see vs foresee

Foresee is a separate but related lexical form meaning:

預見未來可能發生的事情

“Nobody foresaw the problem.”

「沒有人預見到這個問題。」

It is useful, but I would treat **foresee** / **foresaw** / **foreseen** as a neighboring family extension rather than simply another grammatical form of **see**.

Because we are doing a full family sweep, it is worth flagging.

Family-extension note: **foresee** / **foresaw** / **foreseen**

foresee = **predict/anticipate beforehand** — 預見; 預料

“They did not **foresee** the increase in demand.”

「他們沒有預料到需求會增加。」

“The consequences were difficult to **foresee**.”

「那些後果很難預見。」

foresee = 在事情發生之前根據判斷預料到它可能出現

Family-extension sweep

After the full sweep, the useful modern family includes:

- **see** — **visual perception** = 看見／看到
- **see** — **film/show** = 觀看
- **see** — **notice** = 注意到
- **see** — **understand** = 明白
- **I see** = 我明白了／原來如此
- **see why/how** = 明白為甚麼／怎樣
- **see someone** = 見面
- **see a doctor/lawyer** = 求診／諮詢
- **see someone** — **dating** = 跟某人約會／交往
- **see** — **experience/witness change** = 經歷／見證
- **see someone do** = 看見完整動作
- **see someone doing** = 看見動作正在進行
- **see if/whether** = 查明／看看
- **see that** = 確保
- **see A as B** = 把 A 視為 B
- **see a possibility/future** = 想像／認為可能
- **see the point/value** = 理解意義／價值

- **see page/section** = 參見／查看
- **we'll see** = 到時看看／再說
- **you see** = 用來補充解釋／理由
- **see someone home/to the door** = 送／陪同
- **seeing** = 看見這種活動／經驗
- **seeing that/as** = 既然／鑑於
- **seer** = 預言者／先知
- **foresee** = 預見／預料

I would exclude rare derivatives such as **seeable**, because although possible, they are not useful enough for normal learner vocabulary.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
see — visual	透過視覺察覺某人／某物存在
see — film/show	觀看／看過某部影片、表演或節目
see — notice	透過視覺察覺到某項值得注意的資訊或變化
see — understand	在思想上理解某個意思、關係、問題或觀點
I see	表示自己已明白剛才得到的資訊／解釋
see why/how	理解某件事情的原因、方式或機制
see someone — meet	與某人見面、碰面或相處
see a professional	親自會見專業人士，以取得診斷、建議或協助
see someone — dating	與某人處於約會／戀愛交往關係
see — experience	某人、地方、行業或時期經歷／出現某種事件或變化
see someone do	看見某個完整動作發生
see someone doing	看見某個動作正在進行
see if/whether	主動查明、確認某件事情是否成立

see that	負責確保某件事情確實發生／完成
see A as B	以某種觀點理解、評價或看待 A, 認為它屬於 B
see — imagine/foresee	在腦中想像某種情況或判斷其可能性
see the point/value	理解某件事情的道理、意義或價值
see page/section	指示讀者前往另一資料位置查看相關內容
we'll see	現在不作確定判斷, 等待未來情況提供答案
you see	用來引出解釋、背景或理由
see someone home	陪同／送某人到目的地並確保安全到達
seeing that/as	根據已知事實引出結果; 既然／鑑於
seer	被認為能預知未來或隱秘事情的人
foresee	在事情發生前預料到其可能出現

For your original sentence

"I **saw** it about a year ago when I was watching television..."

The exact meaning is:

saw = 在看電視的過程中, 透過視覺看到／注意到那則廣告

So naturally:

"I **saw** it about a year ago..."

= 「我大約在一年前看到那則廣告.....」

And your sentence gives a beautiful contrast:

saw = 看到了某一則特定廣告

was watching = 當時正在持續觀看電視

That distinction alone makes **see vs watch** excellent MCQ material.